

JOIN THE CONVERSATION

Be a part of it.

*Your voice can start a conversation.
Your action can create change.*

My small step this week

Work together and take small, meaningful steps. Tick one or more, and try them in the next 7 days.

- ☐ **Check in on a friend**
Send a message: “How are you, really?”
- ☐ **Listen without judging**
Let someone finish before you reply.
- ☐ **Share an idea or concern**
In class, at home or with a friend.
- ☐ **Challenge stigma**
Speak up about hurtful words or jokes.
- ☐ **Offer peer support**
Go with someone when they seek help.
- ☐ **Include others**
Ask the quiet person in the group for their view.

MY OWN STEP

DATE I DID IT _____



Better together: tell a friend which step you chose, and check in on each other’s steps next week.

IF YOU NEED TO TALK

Where to find support

Reaching out is a strength — you don’t have to go through it alone.



Someone you trust

A friend, family member, teacher or mentor.



Your university counselling service

Confidential support for students. Ask your department office or advisor where to go.



Shastho Batayon · health helpline

16263

Government health call centre, 24 hours.



In an emergency

999

National Emergency Service, 24 hours.

Share with care

Every story is different — share with consent, listen with respect. Never pass on someone’s story without their permission. One person’s experience doesn’t speak for everyone.

When to check in

Someone seems withdrawn, low or not themselves for a while? Ask gently, listen, and help them reach support. If they talk about not wanting to live, stay with them and get help straight away.

#RealVoicesRealChange

World Mental Health Day · 10 October 2026

Prepared by Group 12: Shoadra, Muna, Mahee · Health and Society

Department of Public Health
Independent University, Bangladesh

◆ IUB · WORLD MENTAL HEALTH DAY 2026 ◆

From Being Heard to Creating Change



*Lived experiences heard:
real voices, real change.*

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Speak



Listen



Understand



Act



Change



**Department of Public Health
Independent University, Bangladesh**
Group 12 · Health and Society

Five steps anyone can take

What is lived experience?

What a person has been through themselves: living with a mental health condition, seeking care, recovering, supporting someone they love, or facing barriers to help.

Why being heard matters

People who have lived it know what actually helps. When their voices are heard and included, support gets better and stigma gets smaller.

“Nothing about us, without us.”

People with lived experience belong in the decisions that affect them.

1 Speak

Don't be afraid to share your ideas and concerns.

TRY THIS

- ◆ Choose someone you trust and a quiet moment.
- ◆ Start small: “I’ve been feeling…” or “I’ve noticed…”
- ◆ You decide what to share, and how much.

2 Listen

Respect other people's opinions and experience.

TRY THIS

- ◆ Give your full attention and put the phone away.
- ◆ Don't interrupt, judge or rush to fix things.
- ◆ Thank them for trusting you.

3 Understand

Hear from different perspectives and identify what needs to change.

TRY THIS

- ◆ Ask: “What would really help you?”
- ◆ Remember that one person's story doesn't speak for everyone.
- ◆ Notice the barriers: stigma, silence, cost, distance.

Words matter when you listen

SAY

“I'm here for you.”
“Take your time.”
“Thank you for telling me.”

AVOID

“Just get over it.”
“Others have it worse.”
“It's all in your head.”

4 Act

Work together and take small, meaningful steps.

TRY THIS

- ◆ Check in on a friend this week.
- ◆ Offer peer support, or go with someone to get help.
- ◆ Include people in decisions that affect them.

5 Create change

Small actions can create a better community.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- ◆ Less stigma, more understanding.
- ◆ Better support that fits real lives.
- ◆ Dignity, respect and belonging for everyone.

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**Join the conversation —
be a part of it.**

Speak › Listen › Understand › Act › **Change**